

How to Remove Adware from Your Android Phone

3 easy methods to stop pop-up ads. No factory reset. No lost photos.

The problem

Ads keep popping up on your phone, even when you are not using a browser. The cause is usually a sneaky app called **adware**. It often hides its icon so you cannot find it.

The usual fix (and why it hurts)

A **factory reset** wipes your phone. You lose your photos, contacts, notes and app data.

A better way

Find the bad app and delete it. **Your photos and other data stay safe.** This guide has 3 methods. Each method has everything you need inside it, from start to finish.

Which Method Should I Try?

Start with Method 1. If the ads are still there, move on to the next one.

Method	Level	What you need
Method 1: Phone Settings	Easy	Just your phone.
Method 2: ADB AppControl	Medium	Your phone, a Windows computer, and a USB cable that can move data.
Method 3: Typing Commands	Advanced	Your phone, a Windows computer, and a USB cable that can move data.

Good to know

Methods 2 and 3 do the same job. Method 2 is **point and click**, which is easier. Method 3 is **typing commands**, which gives you more control. You only need to do **one** of them.

Method 1: Phone Settings

Level: Easy **You need:** Just your phone

This is the easiest way. You do not need a computer or any downloads. Many people fix the problem right here.

Step 1 Turn off the internet

Turn off **Wi-Fi** and **mobile data**. With no internet, the ads cannot load.

Step 2 Clear the data of your apps

Open **Settings**, then **Apps**. Tap your **web browser** (like Chrome) and any app that looks suspicious. In each one, tap **Storage** and then **Clear data**.

Good to know

Clearing your browser's data signs you out of websites. Keep your passwords handy.

Step 3 Delete apps you do not need

Still in the **Apps** list, look for apps you do not need or do not remember installing. Delete them. Here is what to look for:

Signs of a bad app

- Fake “cleaner”, “booster” or “battery saver” apps
- PDF or document readers you do not remember installing
- Strange or random names, like com.xjf.lqo
- No icon, no name, or a blank icon
- Fake “System Update” apps

Not sure about an app? Search its name on Google with the word **adware**, for example: Super Cleaner adware. If it is a trusted app from a big company, keep it.

Step 4 Turn the internet back on

Turn **Wi-Fi** or **mobile data** back on. Use your phone for a few minutes and watch if the ads come back.

Step 5 Check the results

What now?

Ads gone? Great! Go to “Keep Your Phone Safe” at the end of this guide.

Ads still showing? Do not worry, this is common. Try **Method 2**.

Method 2: ADB AppControl

Level: Medium **You need:** Windows computer, USB cable (that moves data), your phone

ADB AppControl is a free program for Windows. It shows **every app on your phone** in one list, even hidden ones. You tick the bad app and click a button to delete it.

PART A: GET READY

Step 1 Unlock the hidden Developer menu on your phone

Your phone hides some advanced settings. We need to switch them on so the computer can talk to your phone.

1. Open **Settings** on your phone.
2. Tap **About phone** (some phones say **About Device**). Then tap **Version** or **Software Information** if you see it.
3. Find **Build number** (or **Version No.**) and **tap it quickly 7 times**. A message will say you are now a developer.

Step 2 Turn on USB debugging

This setting lets your computer talk to your phone.

1. Go back to the main **Settings** screen.
2. Open **Additional Settings** (or **System**), then tap **Developer options**.
3. Scroll down and turn on **USB debugging**. Tap **OK** when asked.

Phone brand tips

Oppo / Realme: scroll further down and also turn on **Disable Permission Monitoring**.

Xiaomi / Redmi / POCO: if you see **Install via USB** or **USB debugging (Security settings)**, turn those on too.

Step 3 Download ADB AppControl on your computer

1. On your Windows computer, open your web browser and go to **adbappcontrol.com**.
2. Download the program. Use the installer, or download the ZIP file and right-click it, then choose **Extract All**.
3. If you use the ZIP file, save the folder on your **Desktop**. Do **not** save it inside the **C:\Program Files** folder.

Be careful

Only download from **adbappcontrol.com**. Copycat websites exist and may give you unsafe versions.

Step 4 Connect your phone to the computer

1. **Unlock your phone** and keep the screen on.
2. Plug it into the computer with the USB cable. If the phone asks about USB mode, choose **File Transfer**.
3. A box will pop up on your phone: **“Allow USB debugging?”**. Tick **“Always allow from this computer”** and tap **Allow**.

PART B: FIND AND DELETE THE BAD APP

Step 5 Open ADB AppControl

1. Open **ADB AppControl** on your computer.
2. If it asks to install **ACBridge** on your phone, say **Yes**. It is a small helper that shows app **names and pictures** clearly. You do not need to open it.
3. Keep your phone **unlocked with the screen on**. The app list may take a little while to appear.

Step 6 Find the bad app

Look through the list of apps. Here is what to watch for:

Signs of a bad app

- Fake **“cleaner”**, **“booster”** or **“battery saver”** apps
- **PDF or document readers** you do not remember installing
- **Strange or random names**, like com.xjf.lqo
- **No icon, no name, or a blank icon**
- Fake **“System Update”** apps

Not sure if an app is bad? Ask Google

Checking takes about a minute:

1. **Copy the app’s name** (or its ID, like com.xxx.yyy). You can also type it out.
2. Open **Google** and paste it in the search box. Add the word **adware** after it.
3. Read the first few results. If they say **adware, malware or pop-up ads**, it is the bad app. Remove it.
4. If it is a **well-known app from a trusted company** (like Google, Samsung or your bank), **leave it alone**.

Still not sure? Ask a friend or visit a phone shop before you remove anything.

Step 7 Delete it

1. Tick the **box** next to each bad app.
2. Click the **drop-down menu** at the bottom right and choose **Uninstall**.

3. Click **Apply**. The bad app is now deleted for good!
4. **Restart your phone.**

Pro-tip: Cannot find the app?

Some adware hides well. You can catch it while it is showing an ad:

1. Wait until an **ad pops up** on your phone.
2. **While the ad is still on the screen**, click the **Console** tab in ADB AppControl.
3. Type this and press **Enter**:

```
adb shell dumpsys window | findstr mCurrentFocus
```

4. The result shows which app is showing the ad. Look for the name like **com.xxx.yyy**. Find that app in the list and delete it.

What now?

Ads gone? Great! Go to **“Keep Your Phone Safe”** at the end of this guide.

Ads still showing? Try **Method 3**.

Method 3: Typing Commands (ADB)

Level: Advanced **You need:** Windows computer, USB cable (that moves data), your phone

This method does the same job as Method 2, but you **type short commands** instead of clicking buttons. It uses a free tool from Google called **ADB**. Do not worry. You only need to copy and paste what is in the grey boxes.

PART A: GET READY

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Step 3 Download Google's ADB tool on your computer

1. On your Windows computer, search online for **Android SDK Platform-Tools** and open the **official Android Developer website**.
2. Download the **ZIP file for Windows**.
3. Right-click the ZIP file and choose **Extract All**.
4. Save the folder on your **Desktop**.
5. Open the folder. You should see a file called **adb.exe**.

Step 4 Open the black command window

1. Open the **platform-tools** folder on your Desktop.
2. Click the empty space in the **address bar** at the top of the window.
3. Type **cmd** and press **Enter**.
4. A black window opens. **Keep it open**. This is where you will type.

Step 5 Connect your phone to the computer

1. **Unlock your phone** and keep the screen on.
2. Plug it into the computer with the USB cable. If the phone asks about USB mode, choose **File Transfer**.
3. In the black window, type this and press **Enter**:

```
adb devices
```
4. Look at your phone. A box will ask **"Allow USB debugging?"**. Tick **"Always allow from this computer"** and tap **Allow**.
5. Type **adb devices** again and press Enter. You should see a long code and the word **device**. That means you are connected!

PART B: FIND AND DELETE THE BAD APP

Step 6 Find the bad app

Every app has a hidden **ID** that looks like **com.company.appname**. We need the ID of the bad app. Try Option A first.

Option A: Catch the ad while it is showing

Wait until an ad pops up on your phone. **While the ad is on the screen**, type this in the black window and press Enter:

```
adb shell dumpsys activity activities | findstr "mResumedActivity"
```

You will see one line with the name of the app showing the ad. The ID is the part that looks like **com.xxx.yyy** (it stops before any **"/"** sign). **Write it down**.

Tip

If you see **com.android.chrome** or your phone maker's name, the ad was not on the screen at that moment. Try again while the ad is showing.

Option B: Check the list of apps

If Option A did not work, type this and press Enter:

```
adb shell pm list packages -3
```

This shows the apps that **you or someone else installed** (not the built-in ones). Read the list slowly and write down any strange names. Here is what to watch for:

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Checking takes about a minute:

5. **Copy the app’s name** (or its ID, like com.xxx.yyy). You can also type it out.
6. Open **Google** and paste it in the search box. Add the word **adware** after it.
7. Read the first few results. If they say **adware, malware or pop-up ads**, it is the bad app. Remove it.
8. If it is a **well-known app from a trusted company** (like Google, Samsung or your bank), **leave it alone**.

Still not sure? Ask a friend or visit a phone shop before you remove anything.

Step 7 Delete the bad app

In this example we use **com.document.readerx.viewer**. Replace it with the ID you wrote down.

```
adb shell pm uninstall -k --user 0 com.document.readerx.viewer
```

If it worked, the window shows one word: **Success**. Then **restart your phone**.

Be careful

Only delete apps you are sure are bad. If unsure, **search the name on Google first**.

If you see **Failure**, check that you typed the ID exactly right.

What now?

Ads gone? Great! Go to “Keep Your Phone Safe” below.

Ads still showing? A factory reset is the last choice. **Back up your photos and contacts first**, because a reset erases everything.

Keep Your Phone Safe

Once the ads are gone, do these quick things so they do not come back.

Step 1 Clean up after Methods 2 or 3

Go back to **Settings > Developer options** and turn **USB debugging** off again.

Step 2 Turn on AdGuard DNS (recommended)

Why we love this one

AdGuard DNS is a free filter that blocks ads, trackers and dangerous websites **across your whole phone**. That includes your browser, apps and games. It also helps stop fake “Your phone has a virus!” pop-ups. It takes about one minute and you do not need to install anything.

How to turn it on:

1. Open **Settings**, then go to **Connection & sharing** (or **Network & internet**).
2. Tap **Private DNS**.
3. Choose **Private DNS provider hostname** (it may say “Designated private DNS”).
4. Type exactly: **dns.adguard-dns.com**
5. Tap **Save**. Done!

Good to know: This works on Android 9 and newer. For extra protection for kids, use **family.adguard-dns.com** instead. It also blocks adult websites.

Step 3 Change these 3 settings

Turn off “Install unknown apps”

Go to **Settings > Apps > Special app access > Install unknown apps**. Make sure every app is **OFF**, especially **Chrome**, **WhatsApp** and **File Manager**. This stops bad apps from sneaking onto your phone.

Limit “Display over other apps”

Adware uses this to put ads on top of everything. Go to **Settings > Apps > Special app access > Display over other apps**. Switch it **OFF** for apps that do not need it.

Check Google Play Protect

Open the **Google Play Store**, tap your **profile picture**, then tap **Play Protect**. Tap the **gear icon** at the top right and make sure **Scan apps with Play Protect** is **ON**.

Final advice

Do **not** download “RAM Boosters”, “Battery Savers” or “Antivirus Cleaners” from developers you do not know. Your phone already has these features built in, and they are safe. Most adware hides inside this kind of app.

Quick Checklist

Done?	Task
☐	Tried Method 1 (phone settings)
☐	If ads remain: tried Method 2 (ADB AppControl) or Method 3 (typing commands)
☐	Checked unsure apps on Google before deleting them
☐	Restarted the phone and turned USB debugging off
☐	Turned on AdGuard DNS (dns.adguard-dns.com)
☐	Turned off “Install unknown apps” and checked Google Play Protect is on